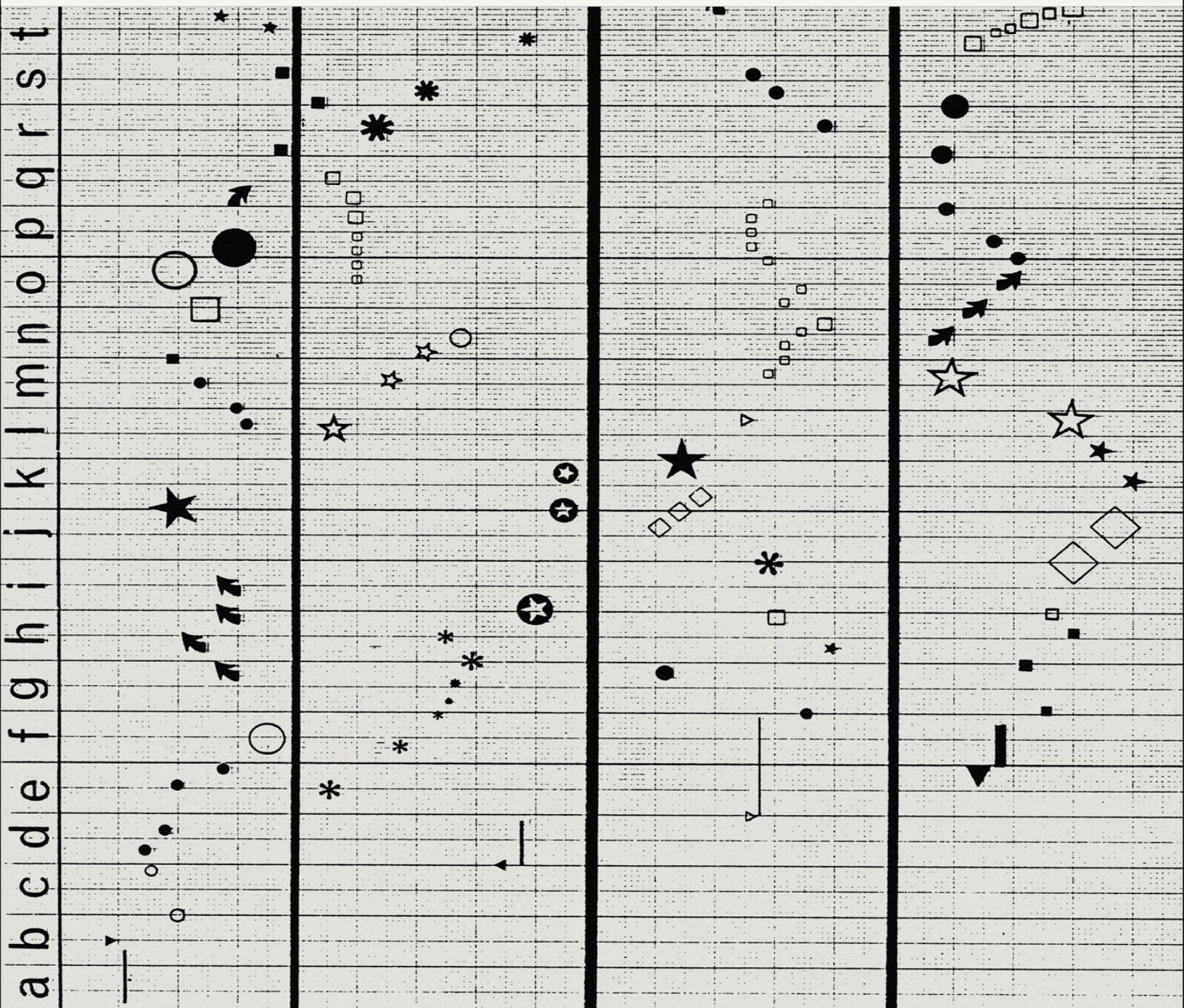




MODERN
CLASSICS

The Penguin Book of Oulipo

Edited by Philip Terry



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Philip Terry

THE PENGUIN BOOK OF OULIPO

Queneau, Perec, Calvino and the Adventure of Form

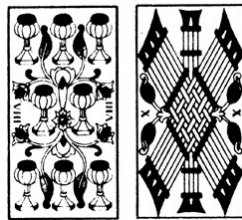


8.

Italo Calvino
THE WAVERER'S TALE

translated by William Weaver
{Oulipo}

One of us turns over a card, picks it up, looks at it as if he were looking at himself in a mirror. True, the *Knight of Cups* really seems to be he. It is not only the face, anxious, wide-eyed, with long hair, now white, falling to his shoulders; the resemblance can be noted also in his hands, which he moves over the table as if he had no idea where to put them. There in the card the right hand holds an outsize cup balanced on the palm, and the left barely touches the reins with the fingertips. This reeling posture is communicated also to the horse: you would say he is unable to plant his hoofs firmly on the plowed earth.



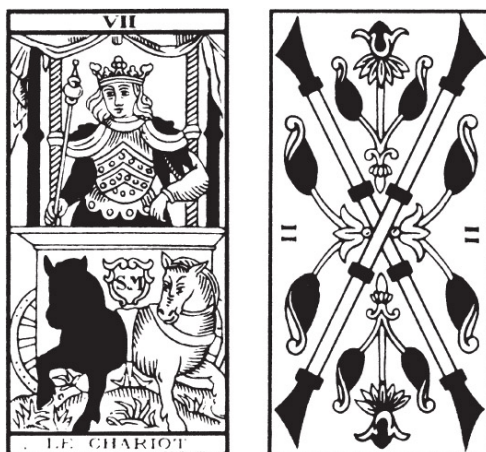
Having found that card, the young man seems to recognize a special meaning in all other cards that come within his reach, and he begins lining them up on the table, as if he were following a thread from one to the other. As, next to an *Eight of Cups* and a *Ten of Clubs*, he puts down the Arcanum that, according to the locality, they call *Love* or *The Lover* or *The Lovers*, the sadness to be read in his face suggests a heartache that impelled him to rise from an overheated banquet for a breath of air in the forest. Or actually to desert his own wedding feast, to run off to the woods on the very day of his marriage.



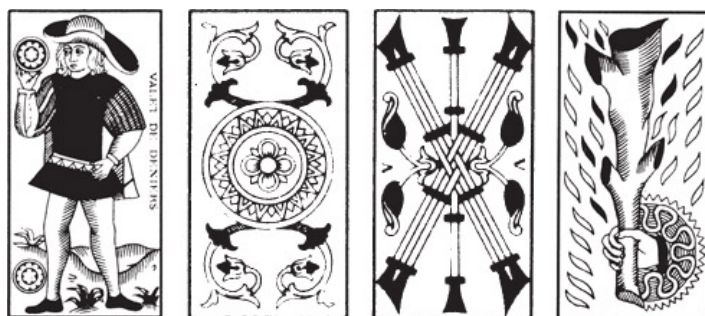
Perhaps there are two women in his life, and he is unable to choose. This is exactly how the drawing portrays him: still blond, between the two rivals, one seizing him by the shoulder and staring at him with a lustful eye, the other rubbing her whole body against him in a languid movement, while he does not know which way to turn. Every time he is about to decide which of the two would be the more suitable bride, he convinces himself he can very well give up the other, and so he is resigned to losing the latter every time he realizes he prefers the former. The only fixed point in this mental vacillation is that he can do without either one, for every choice has an obverse, that is to say a renunciation, and so there is no difference between the act of choosing and the act of renouncing.

Only a journey could release him from this vicious circle: the tarot the young man now puts on the table will surely be *The Chariot*: the two horses draw the stately vehicle along the rough paths through the forest; the reins are slack, for he habitually lets the animals have their way, so when they reach a crossroads he does not have to make the choice. The *Two of Clubs* marks the crossing of two roads; the horses start tugging, one this way, one that; the wheels are drawn to such a divergence they seem perpendicular to the road, a sign that the chariot has stopped. Or else, if it is moving, it might as well remain still, as happens to many people before whom the ramps of the most smooth and speedy roads open, flying on high pylons, over

valleys, piercing granite mountains, and they are free to go everywhere, and everywhere is always the same. Thus we saw him printed there in the falsely decisive pose, like the master of his fate, a triumphant vehicle-driver; but he bore always within him his divided soul, like the two masks with divergent gaze that he wore on his cloak.

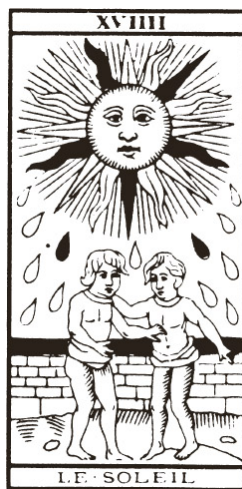


To decide which road to take he could only rely on chance: the *Page of Coins* depicts the youth as he throws a coin in the air: heads or tails. Perhaps neither; the coin rolls and rolls, then remains erect in a bush, at the foot of an old oak, right in the middle of the two roads. With the *Ace of Clubs* the youth surely wishes to tell us that, unable to decide whether to continue in one direction or the other, he had no course save to get down from the chariot and climb up a gnarled trunk, among the branches which, with their succession of repeated forks, continue to inflict the torment of choice on him.



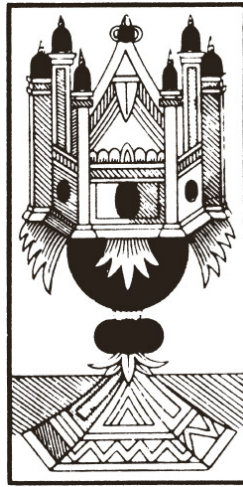
He hopes at least that after pulling himself up from one branch to another he will be able to see farther, discover where the roads lead; but the foliage beneath him is dense, the ground is soon out of sight, and if he raises his eyes toward the top of the tree he is blinded by *The Sun*, whose piercing rays make the leaves gleam with every color, against the light. However, the meaning of those two children seen in the tarot should also be explained: they must indicate that, looking up, the young man has realized he is no longer alone in the tree; two urchins have preceded him, scrambling up the boughs.

They seem twins: identical, barefoot, golden blond. Perhaps at this point the young man spoke, asked: 'What are you two doing here?' Or else: 'How far is it to the top?' And the twins replied, indicating with confused gesticulation toward something seen on the horizon of the drawing, beneath the sun's rays: the walls of a city.



But where are these walls located, with respect to the tree? The *Ace of Cups* portrays, in fact, a city, with many towers and spires and minarets and domes rising above the walls. And also palm fronds, pheasants' wings, fins of blue moonfish, which certainly jut from the city's gardens, aviaries, aquariums, among which we can imagine the two urchins, chasing each other and vanishing. And this city seems balanced on top of a pyramid, which could also be the top of the great tree; in other words, it would be a city suspended on the

highest branches like a bird's nest, with hanging foundations like the aerial roots of certain plants which grow at the top of other plants.



As they lay down the cards, the young man's hands are increasingly slow and uncertain, and we have ample time to follow him with our conjectures, and to ponder silently the questions that must certainly have come into his head as they now come into ours. 'What city is this? Is this the City of All? Is this the city where all parts are joined, all choices balanced, where the void between what we expect of life and what we draw is filled?'

But who was there, in the city, whom the youth could question? Let us imagine he has entered through the arched gate in the girdle of the walls, he has stepped into a square with a high stairway at the end, and at the top of this stairway there is seated a personage with royal attributes, an enthroned divinity or crowned angel. (Behind the personage two protuberances can be seen, which could be the back of the throne, but also a pair of wings, awkwardly traced in the drawing.)

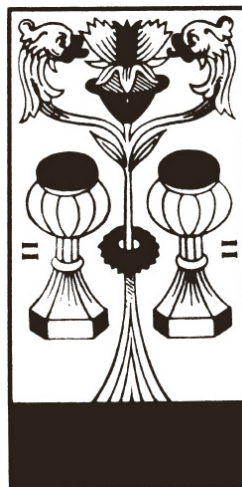


‘Is this your city?’ the youth must have inquired.

‘Yours.’ He could have received no better answer. ‘Here you will find what you ask.’

Taken by surprise like this, how could he express a sensible request? Hot from his climb to that height, he could have said only: ‘I am thirsty.’

And the enthroned angel said: ‘You need only choose from which well to drink.’ And he must have pointed to the two identical wells that open in the deserted square.



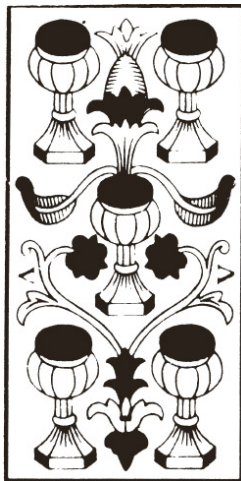
You have merely to glance at the youth to realize he feels lost once again. The crowned authority now wields a scales and a sword, the attributes of the angel who keeps watch over decisions and balances,

from the summit of the constellation of Libra. Are you then admitted even into the City of All only through a choice and a rejection, accepting one side and rejecting the rest? He might as well leave as he came; but, turning, he sees two *Queens* looking down from two balconies, facing each other from opposite sides of the square. And lo! he seems to recognize the two women of his eluded choice. They seem to be there on guard, to prevent his leaving the city, for in fact each is holding an unsheathed sword, one with her right hand, the other – surely for symmetry's sake – with her left. Or else, while there can be no doubts about one queen's sword, the other's could also be a goose-quill pen, or closed compasses, or a flute, or a paper-knife, and then the two women would signify two different ways open to him who still has to find himself: the way of passions, which is always a way of action, aggressive, with abrupt shifts, and the way of wisdom, which demands reflection and learning little by little.



In arranging and pointing to the cards, the youth's hands now hint at vacillation and changes in the order; now the hands are wrung, regretting every tarot already played, which might better have been

kept in reserve for another round, now they droop in limp gestures of indifference, to indicate that all tarots and all wells are the same, like the *cups* which are repeated, identical, in the pack, as, in the world of the uniform, objects and destinies are scattered before you, interchangeable and unchanging, and he who believes he makes decisions is deluded.



How to explain that, with his consuming thirst, neither this well nor that would suffice? What he wants is the cistern where the waters of all wells and all rivers are poured and mingled, the sea depicted in the Arcanum known as *The Star* or *The Stars*, where life's aquatic origins are celebrated as the triumph of mixture and of squandered opulence. A naked goddess takes two jugs containing who knows what juices kept cool for the thirsty (all around there are the yellow dunes of a sun-baked desert), and empties them to water the pebbled shore: and at that instant a growth of saxifrage springs up in the midst of the desert, and among the succulent leaves a blackbird sings; life is the waste of material thrown away, the sea's cauldron merely repeats what happens within constellations that for billions of years go on pounding atoms in the mortars of their explosions, obvious here even in the milk-colored sky.



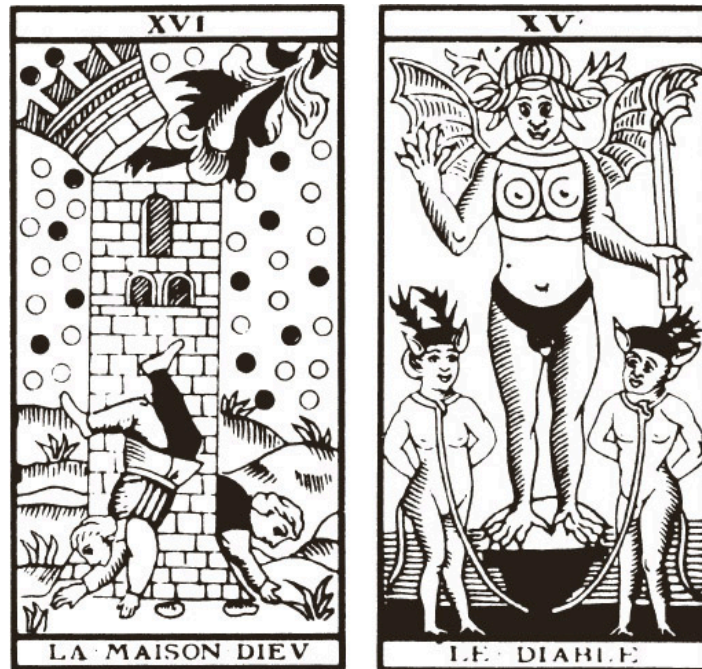
In the way the youth slams these cards on the table we can almost hear him shouting: 'It's the sea! It's the sea I want!'

'And you shall have the sea!' The reply of the astral authority could only announce a cataclysm, the rising of the oceans' level toward the abandoned cities, lapping the paws of the wolves that have taken refuge on the heights and howl toward *The Moon* looming over them, while the army of crustaceans advances from the depth of the abysses to reconquer the globe.



A thunderbolt that strikes the top of the tree, breaking every wall and *tower* of the suspended city, illuminates an even more horrifying sight, for which the youth prepares us, uncovering a card with a slow movement and with terrified eyes. Rising to his feet on his throne,

the regal interlocutor changes and becomes unrecognizable: at his back it is not an angelic plumage that opens, but two bat-wings that darken the sky, the impassive eyes have become crossed, oblique, and the crown has sprouted horn branches, the cloak falls to reveal a naked, hermaphroditic body, hands and feet prolonged into talons.

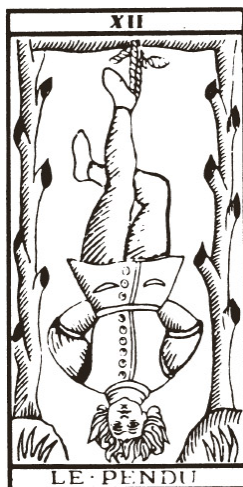


‘Why, were you not an angel?’

‘I am the angel who dwells in the point where lines fork. Whoever retraces the way of divided things encounters me, whoever descends to the bottom of contradictions runs into me, whoever mingles again what was separated feels my membraned wing brush his cheek!’

At his feet the solar twins have reappeared, transformed into two beings whose features are both human and animal, with horns, tail, feathers, paws, scales, linked to the rapacious character by two long threads or umbilical cords, and it is likewise probable that each of them holds on a leash two other, smaller devils that have remained outside the picture, so that from branch to branch stretches a network of ropes which the wind sways like a great cobweb, amid a flutter of black wings of decreasing size: noctules, owls, hoopoes, moths, hornets, gnats.

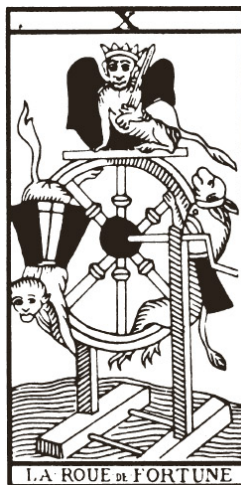
The wind, or waves? The lines drawn at the bottom of the card could indicate that the great tide is already engulfing the top of the tree and all vegetation is being dissolved in a swaying of algae and tentacles. This is the answer to the choice of the man who does not choose: now he does indeed have the sea, he plunges into it headlong, swaying among the corals of the depths, *Hanged* by his feet in the sargassoes that hover half-submerged beneath the ocean's opaque surface, and his green seaweed hair brushes the steep ocean beds. (Is this then the very card that Madame Sosostriis, famous clairvoyante but not very reliable as to nomenclature, in prophesying the private and general destiny of the distinguished Lloyds employee, described as a drowned Phoenician sailor?)



If the only thing he wished was to escape from individual limitation, from categories, roles, to hear the thunder that rumbles in molecules, the mingling of prime and ultimate substances, this then is the path that opens to him through the Arcanum known as *The World*: Venus dances in the sky, crowned with vegetation, surrounded by incarnations of multiform Zeus; every species and individual and the whole history of the human race are only a random link in a chain of evolutions and mutations.

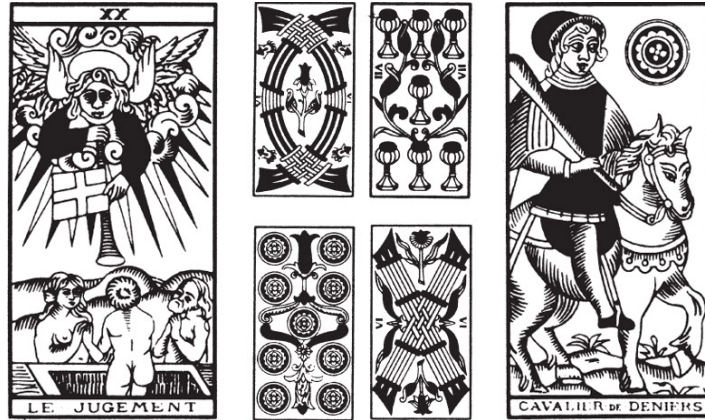


He has only to conclude the great turn of *The Wheel* in which animal life evolves and in which you can never say this is the top and this is the bottom, or the even longer turn which passes through decay, the descent to the center of the earth in the deposits of the elements, the awaiting of the cataclysms that shuffle the tarot pack and bring the buried strata to the surface, as in the Arcanum of the final earthquake.



The hands' trembling, the prematurely white hair were only faint signs of what our hapless neighbor had undergone: in that same night he had been chopped (*swords*) into his prime elements, he had gone through the craters of volcanoes (*cups*), through all the eras of the earth, he had risked remaining prisoner of the definitive

immobility of crystal (*coins*), and had reappeared in life through the painful blossoming of the forest (*clubs*), until he had resumed his own identical human form, in the saddle, the *Knight of Coins*.



But is this really he or is it rather a double whom he saw coming through the forest, the moment he was restored to himself?

‘Who are you?’

‘I am the man who was to marry the girl you did not choose, who was to take the other road at the crossing, quench his thirst at the other well. By not choosing, you have prevented my choice.’

‘Where are you going?’

‘To an inn different from the one you will come upon.’

‘Where shall I see you again?’

‘Hanging from a gallows different from the one where you will have hanged yourself. Farewell.’

17.

Jorge Luis Borges
THE GARDEN OF FORKING PATHS

translated by Andrew Hurley
{Anticipatory Plagiarism}

On page 252 of Liddell Hart's *History of World War I* you will read that an attack against the Serre-Montauban line by thirteen British divisions (supported by 1,400 artillery pieces), planned for 24 July 1916, had to be postponed until the morning of the 29th. The torrential rains, Captain Liddell Hart comments, caused this delay, an insignificant one, to be sure.

The following statement, dictated, reread and signed by Dr Yu Tsun, former professor of English at the *Hochschule* at Tsingtao, throws an unsuspected light over the whole affair. The first two pages of the document are missing.

'... and I hung up the receiver. Immediately afterwards, I recognized the voice that had answered in German. It was that of Captain Richard Madden. Madden's presence in Viktor Runeberg's apartment meant the end of our anxieties and – but this seemed, *or should have seemed*, very secondary to me – also the end of our lives. It meant that Runeberg had been arrested or murdered.^{[fn1](#)} Before the sun set on that day, I would encounter the same fate. Madden was implacable. Or rather, he was obliged to be so. An Irishman at the service of England, a man accused of laxity and perhaps of treason, how could he fail to seize and be thankful for such a miraculous

opportunity: the discovery, capture, maybe even the death of two agents of the German Empire? I went up to my room: absurdly I locked the door and threw myself on my back on the narrow iron cot. Through the window I saw the familiar roofs and the cloud-shaded six o'clock sun. It seemed incredible to me that that day without premonitions or symbols should be the one of my inexorable death. In spite of my dead father, in spite of having been a child in a symmetrical garden of Hai Feng, was I – now – going to die? Then I reflected that everything happens to a man precisely, precisely now. Centuries of centuries and only in the present do things happen; countless men in the air, on the face of the earth and the sea, and all that really is happening is happening to me ... The almost intolerable recollection of Madden's horselike face banished these wanderings. In the midst of my hatred and terror (it means nothing to me now to speak of terror, now that I have foiled Richard Madden, now that my throat yearns for the noose) it occurred to me that that tumultuous and doubtless happy warrior did not suspect that I possessed the Secret. The name of the exact location of the new British artillery park on the River Ancre. A bird streaked across the grey sky and blindly I translated it into an aeroplane and that aeroplane into many (against the French sky) annihilating the artillery station with vertical bombs. If only my mouth, before a bullet shattered it, could cry out that secret name so it could be heard in Germany ... My human voice was very weak. How might I make it carry to the ear of the Chief? To the ear of that sick and hateful man who knew nothing of Runeberg and me save that we were in Staffordshire and who was waiting in vain for our report in his arid office in Berlin, endlessly examining newspapers ... I said out loud: *I must flee*. I sat up noiselessly, in a useless perfection of silence, as if Madden were already lying in wait for me. Something – perhaps the mere vain ostentation of proving my resources were nil – made me look through my pockets. I found what I knew I would find. The American watch, the nickel chain and the square coin, the key ring with the incriminating useless keys to Runeberg's apartment, the notebook, a letter which I resolved to

destroy immediately (and which I did not destroy), a crown, two shillings and a few pence, the red and blue pencil, the handkerchief, the revolver with one bullet. Absurdly, I took it in my hand and weighed it in order to inspire courage within myself. Vaguely I thought that a pistol report can be heard at a great distance. In ten minutes my plan was perfected. The telephone book listed the name of the only person capable of transmitting the message; he lived in a suburb of Fenton, less than a half hour's train ride away.

I am a cowardly man. I say it now, now that I have carried to its end a plan whose perilous nature no one can deny. I know its execution was terrible. I didn't do it for Germany, no. I care nothing for a barbarous country which imposed upon me the abjection of being a spy. Besides, I know of a man from England – a modest man – who for me is no less great than Goethe. I talked with him for scarcely an hour, but during that hour he was Goethe ... I did it because I sensed that the Chief somehow scorned people of my race – for the innumerable ancestors who merge within me. I wanted to prove to him that a yellow man could save his armies. Besides, I had to flee from Captain Madden. His hands and his voice could call at my door at any moment. I dressed silently, bade farewell to myself in the mirror, went downstairs, scrutinized the peaceful street and went out. The station was not far from my home, but I judged it wise to take a cab. I argued that in this way I ran less risk of being recognized; the fact is that in the deserted street I felt myself visible and vulnerable, infinitely so. I remember that I told the cab driver to stop a short distance before the main entrance. I got out with voluntary, almost painful slowness; I was going to the village of Ashgrove but I bought a ticket for a more distant station. The train left within a very few minutes, at eight-fifty. I hurried; the next one would leave at nine-thirty. There was hardly a soul on the platform. I went through the coaches; I remember a few farmers, a woman dressed in mourning, a young boy who was reading with fervour the *Annals* of Tacitus, a wounded and happy soldier. The coaches jerked forward at last. A man whom I recognized ran in vain to the end of

the platform. It was Captain Richard Madden. Shattered, trembling, I shrank into the far corner of the seat, away from the dreaded window.

From this broken state I passed into an almost abject happiness. I told myself that the duel had already begun and that I had won the first encounter by frustrating, even if for forty minutes, even if by a stroke of fate, the attack of my adversary. I argued that the victory was not slight, since without the precious difference that the train schedule afforded me, I would be in jail or dead. I argued (no less fallaciously) that my cowardly happiness proved that I was a man capable of carrying out the adventure successfully. From this weakness I took strength that did not abandon me. I foresee that man will resign himself each day to more atrocious undertakings; soon there will be no one but warriors and brigands; I give them this counsel: *The author of an atrocious undertaking ought to imagine that he has already accomplished it, ought to impose upon himself a future as irrevocable as the past.* Thus I proceeded as my eyes of a man already dead registered the elapsing of that day, which was perhaps the last, and the diffusion of the night. The train ran gently along, amid ash trees. It stopped, almost in the middle of the fields. No one announced the name of the station. 'Ashgrove?' I asked a few lads on the platform. 'Ashgrove,' they replied. I got off.

A lamp enlightened the platform but the faces of the boys were in shadow. One questioned me, 'Are you going to Dr Stephen Albert's house?' Without waiting for my answer, another said, 'The house is a long way from here, but you won't get lost if you take this road to the left and at every crossroads turn again to your left.' I tossed them a coin (my last), descended a few stone steps and started down the solitary road. It went downhill, slowly. It was of elemental earth; overhead the branches were tangled; the low full moon seemed to accompany me.

For an instant, I thought that Richard Madden in some way had penetrated my desperate plan. Very quickly, I understood that that was impossible. The instructions to turn always to the left reminded

me that such was the common procedure for discovering the central point of certain labyrinths. I have some understanding of labyrinths: not for nothing am I the great grandson of that Ts'ui Pên who was governor of Yunnan and who renounced worldly power in order to write a novel that might be even more populous than the *Hung Lu Meng* and to construct a labyrinth in which all men would become lost. Thirteen years he dedicated to these heterogeneous tasks, but the hand of a stranger murdered him – and his novel was incoherent and no one found the labyrinth. Beneath English trees I meditated on that lost maze: I imagined it inviolate and perfect at the secret crest of a mountain; I imagined it erased by rice fields or beneath the water; I imagined it infinite, no longer composed of octagonal kiosks and returning paths, but of rivers and provinces and kingdoms ... I thought of a labyrinth of labyrinths, of one sinuous spreading labyrinth that would encompass the past and the future and in some way involve the stars. Absorbed in these illusory images, I forgot my destiny of one pursued. I felt myself to be, for an unknown period of time, an abstract perceiver of the world. The vague, living countryside, the moon, the remains of the day worked on me, as well as the slope of the road which eliminated any possibility of weariness. The evening was intimate, infinite. The road descended and forked among the now confused meadows. A high-pitched, almost syllabic music approached and receded in the shifting of the wind, dimmed by leaves and distance. I thought that a man can be an enemy of other men, of the moments of other men, but not of a country: not of fireflies, words, gardens, streams of water, sunsets. Thus I arrived before a tall, rusty gate. Between the iron bars I made out a poplar grove and a pavilion. I understood suddenly two things, the first trivial, the second almost unbelievable: the music came from the pavilion, and the music was Chinese. For precisely that reason I had openly accepted it without paying it any heed. I do not recall if there was a bell or a buzzer or if I clapped my hands. The sparkling of the music continued.

From the rear of the secluded house within a lantern approached: a lantern that the trees sometimes striped and sometimes eclipsed, a paper lantern that had the form of a drum and the colour of the moon. A tall man bore it. I didn't see his face for the light blinded me. He opened the door and said slowly, in my own language: 'I see that the pious Hsi P'êng persists in correcting my solitude. You no doubt wish to see the garden?'

I recognized the name of one of our consuls and I replied, disconcerted, 'The garden?'

'The garden of forking paths.'

Something stirred in my memory and I uttered with incomprehensible certainty, 'The garden of my ancestor Ts'ui Pên.'

'Your ancestor? Your illustrious ancestor? Come in.'

The damp path zigzagged like those of my childhood. We came to a library of Eastern and Western books. I recognized bound in yellow silk several volumes of the Lost Encyclopaedia, edited by the Third Emperor of the Luminous Dynasty but never printed. The record on the phonograph revolved next to a bronze phoenix. I also recall a *famille rose* vase and another, many centuries older, of that shade of blue which our craftsmen copied from the potters of Persia ...

Stephen Albert observed me with a smile. He was, as I have said, very tall, sharp-featured, with grey eyes and a grey beard. There was something of a priest about him and also of a sailor; later he told me that he had been a missionary in Tientsin 'before aspiring to become a Sinologist'.

We sat down – I on a long, low divan, he with his back to the window and a tall circular clock. I calculated that my pursuer, Richard Madden, could not arrive for at least an hour. My irrevocable determination could wait.

'An astounding fate, that of Ts'ui Pên,' Stephen Albert said. 'Governor of his native province, learned in astronomy, in astrology and in the tireless interpretation of the canonical books, chess player, famous poet and calligrapher – he abandoned all this in order to compose a book and a maze. He renounced the pleasures of both

tyranny and justice, of his populous couch, of his banquets and even of erudition – all to close himself up for thirteen years in the Pavilion of the Limpid Solitude. When he died, his heirs found nothing save chaotic manuscripts. His family, as you may be aware, wished to condemn them to the fire, but his executor – a Taoist or Buddhist monk – insisted on their publication.’

‘We descendants of Ts’ui Pên,’ I replied, ‘continue to curse that monk. Their publication was senseless. The book is an indeterminate heap of contradictory drafts. I examined it once: in the third chapter the hero dies, in the fourth he is alive. As for the other undertaking of Ts’ui Pên, his labyrinth ...’

‘Here is Ts’ui Pên’s labyrinth,’ he said, indicating a tall lacquered desk.

‘An ivory labyrinth!’ I exclaimed. ‘A tiny labyrinth.’

‘A labyrinth of symbols,’ he corrected. ‘An invisible labyrinth of time. To me, a barbarous Englishman, has been entrusted the revelation of this diaphanous mystery. After more than a hundred years, the details are irretrievable; but it is not hard to conjecture what happened. Ts’ui Pên must have said once: *I am withdrawing to write a book*. And another time: *I am withdrawing to construct a labyrinth*. Every one imagined two works; to no one did it occur that the book and the maze were one and the same thing. The Pavilion of the Limpid Solitude stood in the centre of a garden that was perhaps intricate; that circumstance may have suggested to men a physical labyrinth. Ts’ui Pên died; no one in the vast territories that were his came upon the labyrinth; the confusion of the novel suggested to me that *it* was the maze. Two circumstances gave me the correct solution of the problem. One: the curious legend that Ts’ui Pên had planned to create a labyrinth which would be strictly infinite. The other: a fragment of a letter I discovered.’

Albert rose. He turned his back on me for a moment; he opened a drawer of the black and gold desk. He faced me and in his hands he held a sheet of paper that had once been crimson, but was now pink and tenuous and cross-sectioned. The fame of Ts’ui Pên as a

calligrapher had been justly won. I read, uncomprehendingly and with fervour, these words written with a minute brush by a man of my blood: *I leave to the various futures (not to all) my garden of forking paths*. Wordlessly, I returned the sheet. Albert continued:

‘Before unearthing this letter, I had questioned myself about the ways in which a book can be infinite. I could think of nothing other than a cyclical volume, a circular one. A book whose last page was identical with the first, a book which had the possibility of continuing indefinitely. I remembered too that night which is at the middle of the Thousand and One Nights when Queen Scheherazade (through a magical oversight of the copyist) begins to relate word for word the story of the Thousand and One Nights, at the risk of coming once again to the night when she must repeat it, and thus on to infinity. I imagined as well a Platonic, hereditary work, transmitted from father to son, in which each new individual added a chapter or corrected with pious care the pages of his elders. These conjectures diverted me; but none seemed to correspond, not even remotely, to the contradictory chapters of Ts’ui Pên. In the midst of this perplexity, I received from Oxford the manuscript you have examined. I lingered, naturally, on the sentence: *I leave to the various futures (not to all) my garden of forking paths*. Almost instantly, I understood: “the garden of forking paths” was the chaotic novel; the phrase “the various futures (not to all)” suggested to me the forking in time, not in space. A broad rereading of the work confirmed the theory. In all fictional works, each time a man is confronted with several alternatives, he chooses one and eliminates the others; in the fiction of the almost inextricable Ts’ui Pên, he chooses – simultaneously – all of them. *He creates*, in this way, diverse futures, diverse times which themselves also proliferate and fork. Here, then, is the explanation of the novel’s contradictions. Fang, let us say, has a secret; a stranger calls at his door; Fang resolves to kill him. Naturally, there are several outcomes: Fang can kill the intruder, the intruder can kill Fang, they both can escape, they both can die, and so forth. In the work of Ts’ui Pên, all possible outcomes occur; each one is the point of departure for other

forkings. Sometimes, the paths of this labyrinth converge: for example, you arrive at this house, but in one of the possible pasts you are my enemy, in another, my friend. If you will resign yourself to my incurable pronunciation, we shall read a few pages.'

His face, within the vivid circle of the lamplight, was unquestionably that of an old man, but with something unalterable about it, even immortal. He read with slow precision two versions of the same epic chapter. In the first, an army marches to a battle across a desolate mountain; the horror of the rocks and shadows makes the men undervalue their lives and they gain an easy victory. In the second, the same army traverses a palace where a great festival is taking place; the resplendent battle seems to them a continuation of the celebration and they win the victory. I listened with proper veneration to these ancient narratives, perhaps less admirable in themselves than the fact that they had been created by my blood and were being restored to me by a man of remote empire, in the course of a desperate adventure, on a Western isle. I remember the last words, repeated in each version like a secret commandment: *Thus fought the heroes, tranquil their admirable hearts, violent their swords, resigned to kill and to die.*

From that moment on, I felt about me and within my dark body an invisible, intangible swarming. Not the swarming of the divergent, parallel and finally coalescent armies, but a more inaccessible, more intimate agitation that they in some manner prefigured. Stephen Albert continued:

'I don't believe that your illustrious ancestor played idly with these variations. I don't consider it credible that he would sacrifice thirteen years to the infinite execution of a rhetorical experiment. In your country, the novel is a subsidiary form of literature; in Ts'ui Pên's time it was a despicable form. Ts'ui Pên was a brilliant novelist, but he was also a man of letters who doubtless did not consider himself a mere novelist. The testimony of his contemporaries proclaims – and his life fully confirms – his metaphysical and mystical interests. Philosophic controversy usurps a good part of the novel. I know that of all

problems, none disturbed him so greatly nor worked upon him so much as the abysmal problem of time. Now then, the latter is the only problem that does not figure in the pages of the *Garden*. He does not even use the word that signifies *time*. How do you explain this voluntary omission?’

I proposed several solutions – all inadequate. We discussed them. Finally, Stephen Albert said to me:

‘In a riddle whose answer is chess, what is the only prohibited word?’

I thought a moment and replied, ‘The word *chess*.’

‘Precisely,’ said Albert. ‘*The Garden of Forking Paths* is an enormous riddle, or parable, whose theme is time; this recondite cause prohibits its mention. To omit a word *always*, to resort to inept metaphors and obvious periphrases, is perhaps the most emphatic way of stressing it. That is the tortuous method preferred, in each of the meanderings of his indefatigable novel, by the oblique Ts’ui Pên. I have compared hundreds of manuscripts, I have corrected the errors that the negligence of the copyists has introduced, I have guessed the plan of this chaos, I have re-established – I believe I have re-established – the primordial organization, I have translated the entire work: it is clear to me that not once does he employ the word “time”. The explanation is obvious: *The Garden of Forking Paths* is an incomplete, but not false, image of the universe as Ts’ui Pên conceived it. In contrast to Newton and Schopenhauer, your ancestor did not believe in a uniform, absolute time. He believed in an infinite series of times, in a growing, dizzying net of divergent, convergent and parallel times. This network of times which approached one another, forked, broke off, or were unaware of one another for centuries, embraces *all* possibilities of time. We do not exist in the majority of these times; in some you exist, and not I; in others I, and not you; in others, both of us. In the present one, which a favourable fate has granted me, you have arrived at my house; in another, while crossing the garden, you found me dead; in still another, I utter these same words, but I am a mistake, a ghost.’

‘In every one,’ I pronounced, not without a tremble to my voice, ‘I am grateful to you and revere you for your re-creation of the garden of Ts’ui Pên.’

‘Not in all,’ he murmured with a smile. ‘Time forks perpetually towards innumerable futures. In one of them I am your enemy.’

Once again I felt the swarming sensation of which I have spoken. It seemed to me that the humid garden that surrounded the house was infinitely saturated with invisible persons. Those persons were Albert and I, secret, busy and multiform in other dimensions of time. I raised my eyes and the tenuous nightmare dissolved. In the yellow and black garden there was only one man; but this man was as strong as a statue ... this man was approaching along the path and he was Captain Richard Madden.

‘The future already exists,’ I replied, ‘but I am your friend. Could I see the letter again?’

Albert rose. Standing tall, he opened the drawer of the tall desk; for a moment he turned his back to me. I had readied the revolver. I fired with extreme caution. Albert fell uncomplainingly, immediately. I swear his death was instantaneous – a lightning stroke.

The rest is unreal, insignificant. Madden broke in, arrested me. I have been condemned to the gallows. I have won out abominably; I have communicated to Berlin the secret name of the city they must attack. They bombed it yesterday; I read it in the same papers that offered to England the mystery of the learned Sinologist Stephen Albert who was murdered by a stranger, Yu Tsun. The Chief had deciphered this mystery. He knew my problem was to indicate (through the uproar of the war) the city called Albert, and that I had found no other means to do so than to kill a man of that name. He does not know (no one can know) my innumerable contrition and weariness.

For Victoria Ocampo

24.

Anne Garréta
FROM *SPHINX*

translated by Emma Ramadan
{Oulipo}

I never alluded to what I had so indistinctly perceived in my sleep, and neither did A***. There were always inexplicable silences between us, a sort of prudishness or reserve that kept us from broaching certain intimate subjects. We kept the evidence hidden away, even avoiding the use of expressions that seemed improper, excessive, or bizarre. A*** would never show any immoderate affection, and I was constantly forcing myself not to criticize the escapades I witnessed. Once, only once, I was weak enough to reveal my jealousy, which had been gnawing away at me. In the same vein, A*** only once slipped in showing tenderness toward me, using words and gestures that we had never before allowed ourselves to use.

This single jealous episode took place in the dressing room of the Eden where, one night, I came upon A*** in the company of a man I had seen fairly often in the wings the previous week, whom I suspected to be A***'s latest lover. Normally I pretended not to give a damn about the goings-on of A***'s libido; the number and nature of A***'s escapades were none of my business. What right did I have to be jealous, since there was nothing between us other than platonic affection? But that night I could not bear to see this lugubrious cretin,

in the seat that I habitually occupied, engaged with A*** in the sort of conversation I had thought was reserved for me alone. This substitution outraged me: the idea that in my absence someone could take my place, could be the object of identical attentions. I was willing to admit that I was not everything for A***, but I refused to accept that what I was, achieved through a hard-fought struggle, could be taken over by someone else, and apparently by *anyone at all*. The sole merit of the lover in question was his idiocy: his inane conversation was doubtless a nice break from the thornier discussions A*** and I typically had. A*** thought he had a beautiful face, entrancing eyes, and good fashion sense. I was shocked by A***'s poor taste, by the appreciation of such an individual: an Adonis from a centerfold with a stupidly handsome face.

I had judged him, a priori, as moronic, and I realized, triumph and despair mixing indissolubly, that it was true, indeed in every way. I was revolted by this pretty boy's attitude, by his dumbfounded acceptance and regurgitation of all conventional hogwash. With the aplomb bestowed on him by age and rank, Monsieur would uphold unconscionable vulgarities, which, moreover, he revered – a proselyte! When I arrived, the conversation was revolving around the countries of North Africa, which he had glimpsed during a recent trip to a resort. He passed briskly from the picturesque story of his trip to general commentary on the countries and the samples of the population that one could encounter in France, 'In *our* country,' as he articulated so well. I reveled in ridiculing a rival in front of A*** and put on a show of systematic perversity. The discussion quickly turned sour: when one realizes that one is being unreasonable, it is precisely then that one employs even more uncouth and violent arguments. The offspring of the 16th arrondissement do not like to be refuted, much less mocked; they never think it beneath them to resort to insults, no matter how low. I left, slamming the door behind me, not without having hurled out an extremely spiteful compliment on the quality and distinction of A***'s lover, whom I referred to with a far more offensive noun.

I was in a very bad mood when I arrived at the Apocryphe, and the music I selected was proof. I exuded my resentment through the loud-speakers, which calmed me down a bit. On the floor that night were some showbiz caryatids, those people that one sees on the covers of popular magazines. They did me the honor of a hello, expecting that I would carry out some of their desiderata: 'Could you maybe play X's latest record ...? He's here tonight, it would be an immmense pleasure for him,' or else: 'When are you going to play some reggae?' It made me snicker that these dignitaries, flush with their new, modern-day power, solicited favors from the feeble authority conferred on me by my position behind the turntables. What an *enormous* privilege it was in their eyes that they should notice me! In granting me the favor of acknowledging my presence, of pouring onto me a minuscule portion of the celebrity they oozed and tried to pawn off as glory, they tried cheaply to coax my kindness. I made them feel the vanity of their approach, and unless they were willing to own up to the humiliation of failure, they had no choice but to laugh at my sneering. And that night in particular they were made to feel the grace of my cynicism, the bursts of my impertinent irony.

Common mortals have other ways of expressing their desires. A club does not get filled every night with only the chic clientele. Because there are a paltry number of remarkable characters – and they are remarkable only because their number is paltry – a mass of individuals of lower distinction are allowed into this sanctuary, a privilege through which they are made to feel honored. They would come to the Apocryphe, attracted by the club's reputation (they don't accept just *anybody* – you, me, any old person), hoping to rub shoulders with some celebrities.

That night I realized something: they pronounce their desiderata, demanding (without really caring) some record, in order to prove that they have a right to be in this milieu where the arbitrary reigns. It's their sole ontological proof, their sole cogito, their foundation and justification. I want, therefore I am; I need, I breathe. I spend money,

they must grant my desire, considering my demands in light of the value that I offer. I pay to exist; the tribute, delivered in kind or in cash, buys the recognition of my right.

My strategy was to inspire incertitude; I derived pleasure in imbuing these souls with doubt by not playing into their pathetic ruses. *Che vuoi?* I was leading them to the brink of an essential anxiety. My reply was always 'maybe.' It was a dangerous game that exposed me to the disapproval, disrespect, or insidious resentment of the people to whom I denied the assurance of being a subject. Each night I would have to confront this great panic of individual desires that were in reality desires for individuation, for furious revindication. Sometimes I would try – utterly in vain but with a perverse pleasure – to make them understand that the sum of individual desires does not add up to the happiness of all. That when it comes to the music in a club the law of the majority is ineffectual; that neither democracy nor aristocracy, nor even oligarchy, is a possible regime for a coherent musical set. I would argue that a good DJ is one who, rather than simply responding to repetitive wishes that are consciously formulaic and elementary (such and such a record, such and such a song), subconsciously manages to fulfill an unknown desire by creating a unity out of something superior to adding up so many records, so many requests. To appease is not the same as to fulfill.

Each night I made such observations that I would occasionally articulate to myself when pedantic disquisition and contempt started to mutually reinforce each other. I had come to the end of this chapter of my *De natura rerum noctis* dedicated to the essence of the position of the DJ when I noticed A*** standing near the bar, no longer accompanied by that new moronic lover, being served a glass of champagne by the barman.

It was late, the Eden had already been closed for some time, and I worried that A***'s arrival at the Apocryphe after our altercation meant trouble. I didn't know if I was supposed to leave my booth and go meet A*** or if I was supposed to wait for A*** to approach me.

Fortunately, we both had the same reflex, and met halfway between the bar and the booth. There was no visible trace of what had happened a few hours before. A*** was drunk, which almost never happened, and from within that drunkenness asked me to dance. People didn't dance as a couple anymore in those days except during retro sequences when the DJ would revive old dance forms such as the bop, tango, or waltz. And that was absolutely what A*** desired: a waltz, nothing less. I was enticed by this extravagance, and besides, why not? At this late hour, only a small number of people remained on the floor. A waltz would serve as a charming exit, and, irresistibly outmoded, could assume the parodic allure that excuses all improprieties. So from the bottom of the crate I took out an LP of Viennese waltzes that I cued with no transition, following some non-descript funk track. Abandoning the turntables, and without any snarky retort this time, I went to dance this waltz.

A***, though drunk, was dancing divinely. A classic routine demonstrates one's sensibility just as much as the unruly improvisations of today's dance steps. While dancing these waltzes – for we danced many in succession – I had the impression that never until this day had I reveled in such a carefree lightness of being. There was no longer anybody but us on the dance floor; no doubt our perfect execution of the steps had intimidated all the amateurs. A*** had a naïve and clichéd fondness for the antiquated world of the aristocracy, an admiration for the bygone, the retro, the image of luxury that Hollywood associates with times past.

A***'s drunkenness, at once dissipated and concentrated by the dance, kept us moving. When the Apocryphe closed, we hurried to the Kormoran. Ruggero had a bottle of whiskey brought to my table that he insisted on offering me for the New Year, and as a thank you for the cigars I had brought him back from Germany. And so I too started to drink. A*** and I talked for a long time about everything under the sun. We were drunk, A*** more so than me. There was a warmth, a hint of complicity between us, which soothed the constant tension of our unfinished business. And this happy understanding,

permitted by our drunkenness, was further reinforced by the illusory intensity of perception brought on by the alcohol. Leaning toward me and speaking with more abandon than usual, A*** suddenly murmured the following question: 'And if we make love, will you still love me after?' Abruptly, I caught a glimpse of what I had given up hoping for, without ever having written it off. It was finally being offered to me, in a whisper and under the extraordinary guise of a fiction, all that we had envisioned and elaborated, that which ultimately gave meaning to all of our stratagems. A*** repeated the query, making it sound like a supplication. I leaned toward A***, not knowing how to respond to the anxiety I sensed in the question.

My only answer was to wrest A*** from the chair and to take us out of this place. Once outside and without having discussed it at all, we hailed a taxi and A*** told the driver the address. Without saying a word, we took the elevator. The fear that I had forgotten suddenly returned and took me by the heart, the fear of flesh that accompanies those first adolescent excitements, an anxiety we attempt to combat too quickly with cynicism. I thought I was going to faint, standing there at last on the threshold of what I had so passionately desired.

I staggered as A*** moved to kiss me; I didn't know what to do except let it happen. The temporal order of events, even the simple spatial points of reference, all disappeared without my realizing it; everything is blurred in my memory. I have in my mouth, still, the taste of skin, of the sweat on that skin; against my hands, the tactile impression of skin and the shape of that flesh. In a sprawling obscurity – either I closed my eyes or my gaze was struck with a temporary blindness – some vaguely outlined visions, and, in my ear, the echo of soft rustlings, of words barely articulated.

I don't know how to recount precisely what happened, or how to describe or even attest to what I did, what was done to me. And the effect of the alcohol has nothing to do with this eradication; it's impossible to recapture the feeling of abandon through words. Crotches crossed and sexes mixed, I no longer knew how to distinguish anything. In this confusion we slept.

46.

Italo Calvino
FROM *INVISIBLE CITIES*

translated by William Weaver
{Oulipo}

Cities & Memory 1

Leaving there and proceeding for three days towards the east, you reach Diomira, a city with sixty silver domes, bronze statues of all the gods, streets paved with lead, a crystal theatre, a golden cock that crows each morning on a tower. All these beauties will already be familiar to the visitor, who has seen them also in other cities. But the special quality of this city for the man who arrives there on a September evening, when the days are growing shorter and the multicoloured lamps are lighted all at once at the doors of the food stalls and from a terrace a woman's voice cries ooh!, is that he feels envy towards those who now believe they have once before lived an evening identical to this and who think they were happy, that time.

Cities & Memory 2

When a man rides a long time through wild regions he feels the desire for a city. Finally he comes to Isidora, a city where the buildings have spiral staircases encrusted with spiral seashells, where

perfect telescopes and violins are made, where the foreigner hesitating between two women always encounters a third, where cockfights degenerate into bloody brawls among the betters. He was thinking of all these things when he desired a city. Isidora, therefore, is the city of his dreams: with one difference. The dreamed-of city contained him as a young man; he arrives at Isidora in his old age. In the square there is the wall where the old men sit and watch the young go by; he is seated in a row with them. Desires are already memories.

Cities & Desire 1

There are two ways of describing the city of Dorothea: you can say that four aluminium towers rise from its walls flanking seven gates with spring-operated drawbridges that span the moat whose water feeds four green canals which cross the city, dividing it into nine quarters, each with three hundred houses and seven hundred chimneys. And bearing in mind that the nubile girls of each quarter marry youths of other quarters and their parents exchange the goods that each family holds in monopoly – bergamot, sturgeon roe, astrolabes, amethysts – you can then work from these facts until you learn everything you wish about the city in the past, present, and future. Or else you can say, like the camel-driver who took me there: ‘I arrived here in my first youth, one morning, many people were hurrying along the streets towards the market, the women had fine teeth and looked you straight in the eye, three soldiers on a platform played the trumpet, and all around wheels turned and coloured banners fluttered in the wind. Before then I had known only the desert and the caravan routes. In the years that followed, my eyes returned to contemplate the desert expanses and the caravan routes; but now I know this path is only one of the many that opened before me on that morning in Dorothea.’

Cities & Memory 3

In vain, great-hearted Kublai, shall I attempt to describe Zaira, city of high bastions. I could tell you how many steps make up the streets rising like stairways, and the degree of the arcades' curves, and what kind of zinc scales cover the roofs; but I already know this would be the same as telling you nothing. The city does not consist of this, but of relationships between the measurements of its space and the events of its past: the height of a lamppost and the distance from the ground of a hanged usurper's swaying feet; the line strung from the lamppost to the railing opposite and the festoons that decorate the course of the queen's nuptial procession; the height of that railing and the leap of the adulterer who climbed over it at dawn; the tilt of a guttering and a cat's progress along it as he slips into the same window; the firing range of a gunboat which has suddenly appeared beyond the cape and the bomb that destroys the guttering; the rips in the fish net and the three old men seated on the dock mending nets and telling each other for the hundredth time the story of the gunboat of the usurper, who some say was the queen's illegitimate son, abandoned in his swaddling clothes there on the dock.

As this wave from memories flows in, the city soaks up like a sponge and expands. A description of Zaira as it is today should contain all Zaira's past. The city, however, does not tell its past, but contains it like the lines of a hand, written in the corners of the streets, the gratings of the windows, the banisters of the steps, the antennae of the lightning rods, the poles of the flags, every segment marked in turn with scratches, indentations, scrolls.

Cities & Desire 2

At the end of three days, moving southward, you come upon Anastasia, a city with concentric canals watering it and kites flying over it. I should now list the wares that can profitably be bought

here: agate, onyx, chrysoprase, and other varieties of chalcedony; I should praise the flesh of the golden pheasant cooked here over fires of seasoned cherry wood and sprinkled with much sweet marjoram; and tell of the women I have seen bathing in the pool of a garden and who sometimes – it is said – invite the stranger to disrobe with them and chase them in the water. But with all this, I would not be telling you the city's true essence; for while the description of Anastasia awakens desires one at a time only to force you to stifle them, when you are in the heart of Anastasia one morning your desires waken all at once and surround you. The city appears to you as a whole where no desire is lost and of which you are a part, and since it enjoys everything you do not enjoy, you can do nothing but inhabit this desire and be content. Such is the power, sometimes called malignant, sometimes benign, that Anastasia, the treacherous city, possesses; if for eight hours a day you work as a cutter of agate, onyx, chrysoprase, your labour which gives form to desire takes from desire its form, and you believe you are enjoying Anastasia wholly when you are only its slave.

Cities & Signs 1

You walk for days among trees and among stones. Rarely does the eye light on a thing, and then only when it has recognized that thing as the sign of another thing: a print in the sand indicates the tiger's passage; a marsh announces a vein of water; the hibiscus flower, the end of winter. All the rest is silent and interchangeable; trees and stones are only what they are.

Finally the journey leads to the city of Tamara. You penetrate it along streets thick with signboards jutting from the walls. The eye does not see things but images of things that mean other things: pincers point out the tooth-drawer's house; a tankard, the tavern; halberds, the barracks; scales, the grocer's. Statues and shields depict lions, dolphins, towers, stars: a sign that something – who knows

what? – has as its sign a lion or a dolphin or a tower or a star. Other signals warn of what is forbidden in a given place (to enter the alley with wagons, to urinate behind the kiosk, to fish with your pole from the bridge) and what is allowed (watering zebras, playing bowls, burning relatives' corpses). From the doors of the temples the gods' statues are seen, each portrayed with his attributes – the cornucopia, the hourglass, the medusa – so that the worshipper can recognize them and address his prayers correctly. If a building has no signboard or figure, its very form and the position it occupies in the city's order suffice to indicate its function: the palace, the prison, the mint, the Pythagorean school, the brothel. The wares, too, which the vendors display on their stalls are valuable not in themselves but as signs of other things: the embroidered headband stands for elegance; the gilded palanquin, power; the volumes of Averroes, learning; the ankle bracelet, voluptuousness. Your gaze scans the streets as if they were written pages: the city says everything you must think, makes you repeat her discourse, and while you believe you are visiting Tamara you are only recording the names with which she defines herself and all her parts.

However the city may really be, beneath this thick coating of signs, whatever it may contain or conceal, you leave Tamara without having discovered it. Outside, the land stretches, empty, to the horizon; the sky opens, with speeding clouds. In the shape that chance and wind give the clouds, you are already intent on recognizing figures: a sailing ship, a hand, an elephant ...

88.

Anne Garréta
FROM NOT ONE DAY

translated by Emma Ramadan and Anne Garréta
{Oulipo}

Ante Scriptum

What's to be done with our inclinations?

Why not write something different, differently than you usually do? Once more, but with a new twist, rid yourself of your self. Shed the accoutrements of this disentangling, keep at bay a little longer, if you can, who you think you are. Since you can no longer conceive of writing except in long and intricate constructions, isn't it time to go against the grain?

Figuring out the next novel on the horizon will take years of research, composition, writing. You pity your few readers and always take care not to exceed their patience and good will. In the meantime, you would like to offer them what you expect they desire: a distraction, the illusion of revealing what they imagine to be a subject. For they charitably assume you to be – a common failing, until further notice – a real me.

You don't have the heart to tell them that no subject ever expresses herself in any narration. And besides, they would refuse to believe this terrifying bit of news – we're still punch drunk on our little selves. So you have resolved, at the very least, to pretend to step out

onto the slippery slope that seems so natural these days and to subject yourself to the discipline of confessional writing. All we seem to do nowadays is tell and retell the stories of our lives. For over a century, we've tried to grasp at ourselves from the same angle, convinced that there's only one key to unlock the secret of our subjectivity: desire.

And you could say, with and against Rousseau, he who invented or perfected our corruption: 'We must have spectacles in the great cities of the post-modern era, and confessions for idolatrous people. I have seen the mores of my times, and I have published these stories.

Would that I had lived in an age when I should have thrown them into the fire!'

The irony delights you before you've even written a line. You will play at a very old game that has become the hobbyhorse of a modernity balking at radical disenchantment: confession, or how to scrape the bottoms of mirrors.

On a September day in 1835, strolling near Lake Albano, a man named Stendhal or Henri Beyle or Henri Brulard – which is it? Who knows ... perhaps all three – draws in the sand the initials of the women he has loved: V, An, Ad, M, Mi, Al, Aine, Apg, Mde, C, G, Aur, and finally Mme Azur. The first name of this last one escapes him. The list of an unlucky Don Juan: 'In reality, I had only six of the women I have loved.'

Here H.B. is tempting you with the outline of a project both melancholy and tinged with cruel irony, and perfectly suited to your convalescence: the stammering alphabet of desire.

If you aim to thwart your habits and inclinations, you might as well go about it systematically. Here's what you have resolved to do (there's no more radical way to differ or dissemble from oneself than what you're planning here). It comes down to a single maxim: Not one day without a woman.

Which simply means that you will allocate five hours (the time it takes a moderately well-trained subject to compose a standard academic essay) each day, for a month, at your computer, aiming to

recount the memory you have of one woman or another whom you have desired or who has desired you. That will be the narrative: the unwinding of memory in the strict framework of a given moment.

You will write as one goes to the office; you will be the archivist of your desires, thirty-five hours a week. Five hours per initial, no more, no less.

You will take them in the order in which they come to mind. You will then put them down, neutrally, in alphabetic order. To hell with chronology.

You will refrain from using your customary instruments: no pen, nothing but the keyboard (to the last syllable of recorded time). No draft, no notebook to gather bits and pieces, no considered and composed architecture, no rules other than the purely material and logistical ones that you've already assigned to the act.

No other principle than to write from memory. You will not try to capture things as they happened, nor will you reconstruct them as they might have happened, or as you might have liked them to happen. You will tell them as they appear to you at the precise moment you recall them.

Stabbing at your keyboard, you will decimate your memories. And who cares if at the end of your five hours of recollection, nothing will have been consummated? Who cares whether we've actually had the women we've desired? Writing at the whim of memory twists and turns on uncertainty. Like desire itself, never assured of its end or its object.

No erasures, no rewrites. Sentences as they come, without plotting them, cut off as soon as they're left hanging. Syntax matching composition.

Perhaps you will finally manage, in some feeble way, to emulate your peers, who recount their every experience, spewing out volumes of life matter – and buy into it.

It would have been better had you kept a journal. But you do not possess the talent of your peers. From day to day, you would have had nothing to report: nothing ever happens to you except in

remembering. You only grasp the moment in distant memory, once oblivion has given things, beings, events, the density that they never have in the broad evanescence of daylight.

Your days are made of vapor, of imperceptible condensation. The world (and you with it) is a phantom that only time, the sands of time, makes visible and in the same moment erases. In full daylight, they don't even cast a shadow. An exquisite sensitivity, a photographic plate slowly revealing the image. But there seems to be no fixer for it: exposed to the light of the screen, of the page, and held too long under our gaze, memory dissolves without remission, leaving behind only the image of an image, a snapshot taken at the moment of recollection. From copy to copy of remembrance, it fades, moves. Soon nothing remains but the caricature – and the few details that the gaze has selectively magnified.

In one fell swoop, you will focus and dissipate yourself through thought. You will give yourself over, at set hours, to a purely discursive mental libertinage, you who have long ago renounced libertinage, and have adopted a simplicity of morals that would amaze your peers. And that you certainly never would have been able to imagine when you believed that you were only living in the present.

You will dissipate yourself through thought, in order to dispel the desires that you might still feel, that you are liable to feel even though you have learned to thwart their most trivial ploys.

Let's say it's a beautiful summer night, that after three months spent lounging on your sofa waiting for the double fracture in your right leg to heal, which left you with two metal plates, thirteen screws, and the leisure to analyze the subtle nuances of physical pain accompanied by the taste of morphine mixed with grenadine, to marvel at your luck, all things considered, in getting off so lightly after that absurd accident. For when you developed the memory of it, you finally saw that it could have cost you your life or your body, cut in half by the force of a relatively serious paralysis, that after these three months and a new lease on life, on movement, it's a truly

beautiful summer night, a night when the body, free at last from too much pain, rediscovers all of its appetites helter-skelter: for dancing, for other bodies, for women. It's a perfect evening for sitting on the terrace of a café, watching the women go by. Desire would surely come hurtling down its slope, natural and abrupt, and before even realizing it you would probably have accrued additional memories.

In this regard, desire and pain are alike – your accident taught you this. Only when they take you by surprise do they get out of hand. You wake up after a respite and they will overwhelm you. To keep them in check requires a cool head, focus and consistency.

To dissipate, evade, or sidetrack your desires, such is the purpose of this little experiment you are attempting and which you hope will suffice to keep you going until you board the plane that will carry you across the Atlantic to the other coast of desire. Or to put it another way, you who were frivolous for so long, a fact the stories that you intend to unwind each day of this month of July 2000 will fully illustrate; you who were frivolous for so long, and you whose natural, and certainly human, tendency (exacerbated by all the typically French fondness for fickleness which confounds grace and flippancy, pleasures of flesh and vanity) is far from tamed. For a long time now, you've resolved to stop living as a slave of your disorderly desires.

For life is too short to resign ourselves to reading poorly written books and sleeping with women we don't love.